

iPhone's future is in the Air

There'll be Apple fanboys who'll swoon over the iPhone Air, calling it the greatest thing since sliced bread. Then there'll be others firmly in the Android camp who'll call it an aberration, Apple's cute but misguided attempt to flex its design and innovation muscle, too little too late.

The truth, as always with Apple, a company that delights and infuriates in equal measure these days, is somewhere in the middle. But I'll tell you this: despite which camp you identify with in the Android vs iPhone divide, you have to go and see the iPhone Air with your own eyes. Touch and feel it, and you'll realise why it's a thin phone unlike any other – the likes of which only Apple can make.

It all starts with the design. Holding the iPhone Air for the first time had me genuinely excited about a new iPhone since the iPhone 4 and iPhone 5S over a decade ago. Even the hardest critics will begrudgingly admit it has an X factor unlike any other smartphone – including other iPhones, past and present. Thin, light, beautiful, elegant. There's something to it for sure, and it's not all just hype.

Beyond its thin frame, the iPhone Air is also the biggest celebration of Apple silicon inside an iPhone to date. The new A19 Pro chip features a 6-core CPU, a 5-core GPU with neural accelerators for enhanced AI performance, the N1 wireless networking chip enabling Wi-Fi 7 and Bluetooth 6, and the new C1X cellular modem for faster, more power-efficient 5G connectivity. It's a hardware flex by the Cupertino giant unlike any other in its history, where it's dared to embed so many critical proprietary silicon inside an iPhone variant that's already defying most mainstream logic, if you think about it.

According to Apple, this step was necessitated by the iPhone Air's need to provide "all day battery" despite its slim frame. The fight for battery space is so real that the new Air is the only iPhone version supporting worldwide eSIM only -- no SIM card slot whatsoever. Packaging most of these Apple silicon chips in the raised camera bump is another important check mark in Apple's journey toward a foldable iPhone around the corner.



"Getting the equation right through the iPhone Air's market run will inform Apple's trajectory with the foldable device expected in a year or so"

Jayesh Shinde
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That camera bump, once maligned, is now playing host to a silicon symphony that could dictate the future of mobile form factors.

Whatever you think about the iPhone Air, one thing's clear: behind all its gloss, veneer and hardware firepower, the iPhone Air needs to be looked at as one half of the upcoming iPhone foldable – expected to arrive as early as next year or in 2027, according to several trusted reports.

If Apple is experimenting with the iPhone Air, it's a different kind of trial compared to the iPhone 12 mini or iPhone 15 Plus – instances where Apple wasn't sure if consumers preferred smaller or bigger slabs. That debate is largely over, and Apple is convinced (as is the rest of the industry) that between 6 to 7 inches is the sweet spot – and the iPhone Air sits nicely in the middle with a 6.5-inch screen.

In making the thinnest iPhone ever, Apple isn't flexing in a vacuum. It's counting on its vertically integrated hardware-software stack to shine, especially in the battery department. Silicon dies will shrink, PCB designs will tighten, but the real leap must come from underlying battery tech – which is what the iPhone Air is expected to showcase, a new high-density silicon anode battery (though Apple hasn't confirmed it).

If true, this could be the first glimpse of Apple's long-guarded moonshot in battery tech innovation.

Getting the equation right through the iPhone Air's market run will inform Apple's trajectory with the foldable device expected in a year or so. In that sense, the iPhone Air is a probe. A strategic chess move in Apple's long game of owning the next form factor shift.

So yeah, don't think the iPhone Air is the latest in a fad of slim phones desperate to create hype in a market plateauing in innovation. Think of it instead as Apple's version of a runway prototype – not just a device to sell, but a design to learn from. A signal to the industry and a whisper to developers: pay attention, this is where we're going. And that's the most exciting aspect of the iPhone Air for me, all things considered. **d**



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